PARRY AND RIPOSTE BJP leaders Suvendu Adhikari and Agnimitra Paul after being suspended from the assembly; February 17



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FAITH HEALING FOR FRACTURE

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

As West Bengal politics warms up for the upcoming assembly elections in 2026, the state unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party finds itself in a precarious position. Racked by factionalism and a floundering organisational structure, it is struggling to maintain its hard-won foothold in the state. To extricate itself from this mess, the BJP has doubled down on its Hindutva narrative to consolidate its core base and counter the formidable Trinamool Congress.

The BJP's bid to emphasise religious issues was witnessed during the controversy surrounding Saraswati Puja at Kolkata's Jogesh Chandra Law College in early February. What started as an internal feud over control of puja arrangements within the Trinamool Congress Chhatra Parishad (TMCP)—the TMC student's wing—soon turned into a full-blown political crisis. Students alleged that TMCP-affiliated 'outsiders' led by one Shabbir Ali had attempted to stop the puja and threatened students. The matter reached the Calcutta High Court, which provided police protection and allowed only students to attend the event on February 2. While the BJP attempted to frame the incident as religious persecution, students and authorities rejected any communal angle.

THE SARASWATI PUJA ROW CAME AS A SALVE FOR THE BENGAL BJP. IT WAS BATTLING TO QUELL PUBLIC DISPLAYS OF ITS INTERNAL SPLITS

Nonetheless, BJP leaders, including leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari and state unit chief Sukanta Majumdar, have drawn parallels between the Saraswati Puja controversy and attacks on Hindus in Bangladesh,